needs to be justified, as well as to legitimize him as the great foreseer; it seems thus that much before he began predicting the future greatness of Ashoka, he prophesied the subsequent pre-eminence of Pataliputra. This prophecy to Ananda is a leitmotif in accounts from the late centuries BCE till at least the time of Xuanzang. In the early texts, however, Ashoka is not credited with the creation of the capital; the Chinese pilgrim's account of the Buddha's prediction about Pataliputra is in this respect novel.

The Buddha's sojourn at and pronouncements about what soon became the pre-eminent city of ancient India point to two crucial factors in the evolution of Pataliputra. One is the role of traders and trade routes in sustaining the city as a crucial hub. This is not surprising, for farmers and fishing folk were familiar with the rivers in the vicinity of Pataliputra from a time well before the Buddha. The links and locales of third millennium BC sites like Maner on the Son river, some thirty-odd km west of Pataliputra, and Chirand on the northern bank of the Ganga, not far from where the Ghaghara river joined it, suggest this. Pataliputra's land arteries too, from the beginning, linked it to Rajagriha and the Chhotanagpur plateau on the one hand, and Gaya–Bodh Gaya and beyond on the other.

The other factor, about improving the defensive strength of Magadha, relates to a more specific sixth century BCE feature. It concerns the shift that was necessitated from hill-girt Rajagriha, the first capital of the state of Magadha, to Pataliputra in the Ganga plains (Figs 2.1 and 2.2). Capitals are known to have been shifted in many other regions, Delhi for example being a city where seven capital cities are said to have come up at different points in time. However, whether Delhi's cities, like Indraprastha and Shahjahanabad, hugged the banks of the Yamuna, or as in the case of Lal Kot and Tughlaqabad, were located in the rocky Aravalli hills, they were all within a few kilometres of each other. Pataliputra and Rajagriha, on the other hand, were not contiguous but separated by a considerable distance—more than a hundred kilometres—with the two cities occupying very